

Sportswriters are now all-rounders

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At irregular intervals, I am asked to give my valuable (their word, not mine) opinion on how sportswriting has changed over the years. I often begin with a quote attributed to Norman Mailer after he had reported on Ali's fight with Foreman:

"The popular assumption that professional boxers do not have brains comes from sportswriters, but then sportswriters' brains are themselves damaged by the obligation to be clever every day. And the quantities of booze necessary to lubricate such racing of the mental gears ends up giving sportswriters the equivalent of a good many punches to the head."

That was written in the 1970s. Much has changed since then. Sportswriters, once merely making up the numbers in a media outfit (formerly known as newspapers), are now all-rounders. We must sup with sources not only in our government but foreign ones too. **How else would we know why Bangladesh pulls out of a tournament or Pakistan threatens to? Half a story is no story at all.**

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It is useful to know how the previous World Cup football was won, but now it is necessary to remember who said what about Iran and where the Strait of Hormuz is in preparation for the one in the U.S. this year. Those covering the Olympics must have more than a nodding familiarity with leading terrorist organisations,



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their standard demands and where it all began. Sad, but true. No sportswriter can afford to be caught off guard.

What the athlete says is sieved through layers of PR people, sponsors and the governing bodies of their sport. It wasn't so long ago that an Indian cricket captain passing a reporter on returning from the toss could hold up a hand with the fingers outstretched to get his message across: India would play five batters and five bowlers besides the wicketkeeper. The last Indian captain to say something

indiscreet was probably the stand-in Virender Sehwag who said ahead of a game that India would have no trouble against Bangladesh because they weren't good enough.

Sport reveals something about our times, something that taps into our culture. The subject matter may be unsophisticated (in a large sense), even meaningless, but what it gives rise to is often historical and perhaps a more honest commentary on the times than historians reveal.

Every emotion that we deal with over a lifetime: joy, sorrow, disappointment, anger, satisfaction, hope, anticipation, frustration, comes packaged in 90 minutes of football or several times over in a five-day Test match.

Sportswriting that fails to reflect this, that limits itself to focusing on the statistics does itself an injustice. This doesn't mean, of course that every match report should read like an Eliot poem or a Pinter play. The best writers on sport are those who write with the wider vision. Their subject just happens to be sport.